

SOPHONIAS

THE PROPHECY OF SOPHONIAS.

PREFACE.

Sophonias, whose name, saith S. Jerom, signifies "the watchman of the Lord,"

or "the hidden of the Lord," prophesied in the beginning of the reign of Josias.

He was a native of Sarabatha, and of the tribe of Simeon, according to the more general opinion. He prophesied the punishments of the Jews, for their idolatry and other crimes; also the punishments that were to come on divers nations; the coming of Christ, the conversion of the Gentiles, the blindness of the Jews, and their conversion towards the end of the world. Ch. --- Some editions read, Ezechias. H. --- But this opinion is not well grounded no more than that of the Jews, who assert (C.) that all the ancestors mentioned by the prophets were endued with the prophetic spirit, for which reason Amos specifies none, as he was not the son of a prophet. C. vii. 14. S. Jer. ---

Sophonias appeared a little before Jeremias, Ezec. Bar. and Daniel, foretelling the captivity and return of the two tribes, the destruction of various nations, the conversion of the Gentiles, and of the Jews also towards the end of the world. W. --- Many of the promises regard only the Christian Church. C.

SOPHONIAS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Lord. Thus the prophets insinuate that they are not the authors but the ministers of God's word. W.

Ver. 2. Gather, &c. That is, I will assuredly take away and wholly consume, either by captivity or death, both men and beasts out of this

land. Ch. --- To gather commonly implies a benefit, but the sequel shews that the contrary is here meant. W. --- It often signifies to kill or bury. Jer. viii.

2. The whole country round Judea to Babylon, shall be a sepulchre for men and beasts. Osee iv.

3. C.

Ver. 3. Sea: the waters and air shall be pestilential. H. --- S. Jerom frequently observes that when a country is depopulated, as the Roman empire was in his days, the most fertile regions were soon abandoned even by beasts and birds.

--- Meet. Sept. "be weak." Heb. "I will gather (C. Prot.

"consume." H.) scandals (or idols) with the wicked." Sym.

Ver. 4. Baal. Josias had not yet begun his reformation. 4 K. xxiii. 4. C. --
- At least he had not brought it to perfection, though from his infancy he had encouraged religion. H. --- Wardens of the temples of the idols. *Ædituos*, in Hebrew, the *Cemarim*, that is such as kindle the fires or burn incense. Ch. ---

Lit. "the blacks, (H.) or those in black," whether it alludes to their clothes or to the colour of their bodies, in consequence of their going almost naked. *Camilli*, which may be derived from this root, (C.) *cemarim*, (H.) in Tuscan, signifies priests, or rather (C.) children who went naked before them. *Macrob.* iii. 8. ---

The priests of Baal appeared in this manner, and cut themselves, (3 K. xviii.

28.) committing great indecencies, while God ordered his ministers to be clothed in white with the utmost gravity. C. --- The very remembrance of such idols and priests shall be abolished. Osee ii. 16. They were designed for the worship of fire. Baal was the sun.

H.

Ver. 5. Houses. The roofs were flat. Josias afterwards reformed this abuse. 4 K.

xxiii. 5. C. ---

It continued among the Arabs. Strabo xvii. --- Melchom. The idol of the Ammonites. Ch. ---

Those who join idols with God do not worship Him indeed. W. --- Swearing was an act of religion. Mat. v. 33. God will not allow his glory to be given to another.

Such lame worship or divided hearts he rejects. 3 K. xviii. 21. C.

Ver. 7. Silent. Heb. has, (H.) an interjection, (S. Jer.) like our hush. H. -- - This denotes the importance of what he is going to say. --- Guests. The blood of the wicked is his victim. Jer. xlvi.

10. Ezech. xxxix. 17. C. --- The day of punishment is commonly styled the day of the Lord. Is. ii.

and 1 Cor. iii. W.

Ver. 8. Victim. Heb. "sacrifice." But MS. 1. Camb. has, "in that day, says the Lord," eeva nam being substituted for zebach, (H.) which is "a very remarkable variation." In v. 7. it has Jehovah Elohim printed Adonai Jehovah. Kennicott. ---

Princes. After the death of Josias all fell to ruin.

His sons were deposed, and led into captivity with the chief nobility and priests, who were richly adorned, and imitated the manners of idolaters, or kept the garments of the poor. Ex. xxii. 26.

Deut. xxii. 5. 11. &c. C. --- All the posterity of Josias was afflicted. Joachaz died in Egypt; Joakim was harassed and put to death; Sedezias taken, and his eyes put out, when his children had been slain.

Jechonias, or Joachin, was detained in prison at Babylon for a long time. W.

Ver. 9. Entereth the temple, as if to shew themselves. Amos vi. 1. Heb.

"jumpeth over," &c.

denoting the Philistines. Chal. 1 K. v. 5. C. --- Sept. "I will take vengeance on all openly before the gate in that day," (H.) on all who have cast themselves out of the Church. S. Jer. --- Lord.

Heb. "of their masters with," &c. This may relate to the Philistines, (C.) or to those who made the house of God a place of traffic, (Matt. xxi. 13.) and offered victims unjustly acquired. H.

Ver. 10. Gate, looking towards Joppe. S. Jer. --- The news of the defeat at Mageddo came this way, or the cries of the Philistines were heard. C. ---

Second. A part of the city so called, (Ch.) built by Manasses on the same side of the city, 2 Par. xxxiii. 14. C.

Ver. 11. The Morter: (Maktesh) a valley in or near Jerusalem. Ch. --- All the people shall suffer in the city. Sanct. T. --- Mactes was rendered famous by Samson, (Judg. xv. 19.) and was in or near the country of the Philistines, who seem to be designated. The original is variously interpreted. C. --- Sept. "of the city cut in pieces, because all the people resemble Chanaan." H.

--- Chanaan. So he calls the Jews, from their following the wicked ways of the Chanaanites. Ch.

--- The merchants (Grot.) are confounded, or (H.) the Philistines are still meant.

C.

Ver. 12. Lamps, with the utmost diligence, (Lu. xv. 8.) so that none shall escape even in the most filthy places. C. --- The Romans found many

Jews in the common sewers. Jos. Bel. vii. 16. 20.

and 26. --- Lees. That is, the wealthy, and such as live at their ease, resting upon their riches, like wine upon the lees. Ch. --- Evil, denying Providence. C.

Ver. 13. Strength. Children or riches. H.

Ver. 14. Near. When all these miseries shall overtake the wicked, (W.) after the death of Josias.

4 K. xxi. 14. C. --- The mighty. Sept. "and dreadful, powerful is the day of," &c.

--- Meet. Prot.

"cry bitterly." H.

Ver. 15. Day, is a day. The repetition elegantly describes the great danger. W.

Ver. 16. Trumpet, when Nachao came and deposed Joachas.

Ver. 17. Blind. Not knowing what course to take. Deut. xxviii. 29. Is. lix. 10. C. ---

Such will be the horror preceding judgment. H.

Ver. 18. Gold. Ezek. vii. 19. Thus the Medes despised riches. Is. xiii. 17. C. ---

Jealousy. God regarded the synagogue as his spouse. M. --- "If he loved not the soul of man, he would not be jealous of it." S. Jer. H.

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CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Together, in love. S. Jer. --- Heb. "gather" the wood or chaff, (C.) your wicked deeds, lest they prove the fuel of fire. C. i. 18. H. --- He addresses the Jews and all their neighbours. C. ---

Though you deserve no love, God will receive the penitent. W.

Ver. 2. The day. Heb. "to-day." C. --- Sept. "before you become as a passing flower." Prot.

" before the day pass as the chaff." H.

Ver. 3. Just. Heb. "justice." C. --- Sept. "righteousness, and answer the same."

H. --- Scarcely the innocent will escape. M. --- The prophet does not specify the crimes of the Philistines, as Ezechiel (xxv. 15.) does. C.

Ver. 4. Shall be, or "is." The prophets often represent future things as past, to shew the certainty of the event. The destruction of other cities by the Chaldees, gave the Jews to understand what they had to expect, as all sin must be punished sooner or later. W. --- Psammetichus, and his son, Nachao, probably fell upon these cities. C. --- The former besieged Azotus for twenty-nine years.

Herod. ii. 157. --- Afterwards Nabuchodonosor reduced the country, beginning with the house of God. Jer. xlvii. 4. Ezec. xxv. 15, &c. C.

Ver. 5. Coast. Lit. "line," (H.) with which land was measured. C. --- Reprobates.

Heb.

cerethim, (H.) or Cerethi, of whom David's guards were formed. C. --- Sept.

"people sprung the Cretans," whence some (Theod.) of the Philistines came, perhaps rather than from Cyprus, as was conjectured. Gen. x. 14. --- Chanaan.

So the Philistines are styled contemptuously. They adored the same idols.

Wisd. xii. 23.

Ver. 6. Shepherds. Merchants shall come no longer, the country being subdued by Nabuchodonosor, and by the Machabees. v. 7. --- Alexander ruined Gaza.

Curt. iv.

Ver. 8. Borders, helping the Chaldeans. This brought on their ruin. S. Jer. ---

They were always disposed to seize the country.

Ver. 9. Dryness. Sept. "Damascus shall be abandoned as a heap on the barn-floor, and disappearing for an age." H. --- This city is threatened with the rest.

Is. xvii. 1. C. --- Ever.

Sept. refer this to Damascus, others to Ammon, &c. H. --- The latter nations were in desolation for a long time; but had re-established themselves, when the Machabees reduced them again. Jer.

xlvi. and 1 Mac. v. 6.

Ver. 11. Own place. The Jewish religion could be practised only at Jerusalem, so that this is one of the most striking predictions of the conversion of the world. The Jews in vain attempt to restrain it to the captives returning. See S.

Jer. C. --- They shall inform many of the truth, and be the means of their conversion. H. --- But God shall be adored in every place. M.

Ver. 12. Ethiopians. Heb. Cushim, denotes also the Arabs, &c. who fell a prey to the Chaldeans.

C.

Ver. 13. The beautiful city. Ninive, which was destroyed soon after this, viz. in the sixteenth year of the reign of Josias. Ch. A. 3378. --- Heb. "he shall make Ninive desolate." H. --- This famous and potent city was at last destroyed. W.

See Jonas iii. 4. C.

Ver. 14. Bittern and the urchin. Heb. kaath and kippod, are terms to us (H.) unknown. ---

Threshold. Heb. "the pomegranates," supposed to be an ornament of the doors. --- Raven. Sept.

also read arb better than choreb, "the desolation or the sword." See Is. xxxiv.

11. C. --- Chereb has both meanings, "a raven, or sword." S. Jer. --- I will. Heb.

"he has uncovered her cedar," (C.) her fine palaces and apartments. Sept. "for the cedar is its height, (or pride) this is the city given to evils, that," &c. H.

Ver. 15. Beside, or equal. This was true. Jonas i. 2. C. --- The founder intended that no city should ever equal it. Diod. ii. S. Jerom applies what is here said of Ninive to the Church in the times of antichrist, (Rondet.) or to a fallen soul. Any nation may abandon the faith: but the whole Church cannot fail. H.

SOPHONIAS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Dove. Jerusalem is upbraided, and then comforted. She had been treated like a spouse, a dove; and yet proved faithless. C. --- Heb. "Wo to the famous, and defiled, and oppressing city."

Sept. agree with us, if we only exchange famous for provoking. H. --- After being redeemed from Egypt, the Jews ungratefully followed idols. Osee vii. 11.

M. --- Jerusalem having been freely chosen and favoured above other places, and still provoking God, cannot escape a severe chastisement. W.

Ver. 2. Lord. She had recourse rather to the princes of Assyria and of Egypt, which proved her ruin.

Ver. 3. Evening. Sept. "Arabian." Hab. i. 8. Such was the state of the kingdom before the reform of Josias. C.

Ver. 4. Senseless. Prot. "light," or (H.) windy and inconstant. There were too many false prophets (C.) during the minority of Josias. C.

Ver. 5. Morning. Speedily he will punish the guilty before all. --- Shame. He is hardened. C. ---

Sept. "and not injustice for victory." Grabe substitutes contention. God is just, (H.) even when he takes vengeance. C.

Ver. 6. Towers. Lit. "angles," (H.) the chiefs, or to the very last. Job xxxviii. 6.

Zac. x. 4. The nations have been punished for an example. But you do not take warning. C.

Ver. 7. But. Sept. "be prepared, rise early, all their grapes are corrupt." H. --- I had reason to expect an amendment, when so many nations had perished before their eyes. C. --- They however sinned out of malice, and strove to provoke me in all their ways.

Ver. 8. To come. Sept. "for a witness." H. --- About forty years after Christ's resurrection, the Jews for the most part continuing obstinate, Titus ruined their city; which is a figure of the world's destruction, and of the eternal punishment of the wicked. W. --- After the resurrection,

the Church was to be gathered from all nations. Christ will rise again at the last day to judge all.

God threatens his rebellious people with captivity, and then promises to shew mercy. v. 9. Thus the prophets often subjoin promises to threats.

Ver. 9. Chosen. Sym. "pure." C. --- Idols shall not be mentioned. Theod. --- All people shall know and adore the Lord, which was verified only after Christ's coming. C. --- Sept. "for then I will change again for the peoples, language to its own kind," (H.) which Origen, (c. Cels. viii.) and the Jews in S. Jerom, explain of the days of the Messias, when the confusion of Babel shall cease.

But this is forced: it suffices that people unite in faith and obey the Church. ---

Shoulder, like people carrying a burden. Sept. "under one yoke." After the captivity the Jews were more obedient and faithful, as the more corrupt remained behind the Euphrates, or were cut off in the last wars. Yet the synagogue was never so pure as the Christian Church, even in the worst times.

C. --- All nations shall worship God in unity of faith, and courageously submit to the gospel. W.

Ver. 10. Ethiopia. The Nile arises in that country, and runs through Egypt and Arabia, which is often styled Ethiopia or Cush. Is. xviii. 1. The Jews came from Egypt to adore at Jerusalem, even after the building of Onion. Yet this literally regard's Christ's Church. --- Offering. The Jews performed this after the captivity, coming or sending the half sicle to Jerusalem annually, from all quarters of the world. Num. iii. 46. Mat. xvii. 23. C.

Ver. 11. Doings. Lit. "inventions," of religion of thy own choice. H. --- Thy past offenses shall be obliterated, and thou shalt commit nothing of the kind any more. Those proud spirits who caused thee to dislike my law, and who set up idols in my temple shall disappear. --- Mountain.

The temple shall be destroyed, that all may know that I am attached to virtue alone, (C.) and not to any edifice or place. H. --- They trusted too much to the temple. Jer. vii. 4. M.

Ver. 12. Poor in spirit. H. --- Heb. "meek and extenuated," who trust not in themselves. This is the character of true Christians. The few Jews who remained in the country, or who returned from Babylon, might well represent them, being poor and dependent. The disciples of Christ contemned riches, and were resolute only where virtue was at stake. C. --- They were instructed by poor fishermen taught by God. M.

Ver. 13. Israel. They shall be more submissive, and afraid of yielding to idolatry. Yet the synagogue was far from the perfection of the primitive Christianity, or even from that of many pious souls in these days of relaxation.

--- Afraid. The Jews were not much molested till the time of Epiphanes, nor was the country ravaged as it had been. Mic. ii. 12. This peace is however of a spiritual nature, granted by Christ to those who fight against their passions.

John xiv. 27. C. ---

They shall feed on the word of God and on the blessed Eucharist. M.

Ver. 15. Judgment, or "condemnation." Sept. "iniquities," (C.) nailing to the cross the handwriting that was against thee. H. --- God does not treat thee with rigour. He will be thy king. The Jews had no king for a long time. But the true Israel, of whom the prophet speaks, is continually ruled and fed by Jesus Christ, who imparts his graces abundantly. C.

Ver. 17. Silent; constant. M. --- He will accuse thee no more. Can this be understood of the Jews, who have been cast off till the fulness of the Gentiles enter the Church? To the latter all this must be applied. Few prophets inveighed against the crimes of the captives after their return.

C. --- But this must be deemed a punishment, unless the crimes were also removed. H.

Ver. 18. Triflers. Lit. "trifles;" nugas. Heb. nugi, (H.) which is almost Latin. S.

Jer. --- These vain nothings, (C.) men who were of light dispositions, scoffers at Christ, shall be converted and honour him. W. --- Sept. 17. "he will renew thee in his love, and will exult over thee in joy, as on a festival day: (18) and I will bring back thy bruised ones. Wo to him that has reproached her."

Aquila likewise renders by woe, or eju, oh, oi, using it as an exclamation, though not of sorrow.

Yet the term signifies, they were. S. Jer. H. --- Heb. lit. "I have gathered those who were in grief for a time. They were of thee. Shame was upon them like a heavy load;" or, "they were grieved on account of the festivals disused. They were like an offering rejected," with disgrace. C. ---

They lamented that they could no longer observe the solemn festivals, and this was to the pious a most intolerable burden, while libertines seem to feel as great a misery in the observance.

Ver. 19. Cut. Sept. "do in thee, for thy sake at," &c. H. --- Halteth, and have no children, (Mic.

iv. 7.) denoting the Gentiles. C. --- Sept. "squeezed out," like grapes, being in distress. S. Jer. ---

Where. Sept. "and they shall be ashamed at," &c.

Ver. 20. Bring. Sept. "do good to you." H. --- Praise. All shall speak well of you who have been lately dishonoured, when I shall take both Gentiles and Jews for my spouse after the captivity, which seems present, (C.) it is so certain. H.

--- Captivity, under satan and sin. M.